



Champion's farewell: Mumbai players carry Dhawal Kulkarni on their shoulders as he thanks the crowd after winning the Ranji Trophy final.

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ultimately securing the top position in the league standings. This achievement was crucial, as finishing with the highest points meant Mumbai would host all its knockout matches.

Furthermore, credit must be attributed to Dhawal Kulkarni, the veteran whose career culminated in a fairy-tale ending.

Despite featuring in only three games, Kulkarni remained actively involved throughout the season, shouldering the responsibility of nurturing a younger pace attack. This was particularly significant, with Shardul Thakur and Tushar Deshpande occupied with national and India A duties for a significant portion of the league stage, with Kulkarni providing guidance and support from the sidelines.

T for team effort

Despite the absence of any Mumbai batter among the top 10 run-scorers, opener Bhupen Lalwani's 588 runs placed him 15th in the Elite Group. Similarly, Avasthi and Shams Mulani, with 35 wickets each, found themselves jointly placed 11th among the wicket-takers.

However, despite these individual statistics, Mumbai stood proudly at the summit of both the league and knockout stages. This achievement underscores the deeply ingrained culture fostered by Rahane and Salvi.

The ethos of "Team first" resonated throughout the season.

Players like Avasthi and Shivam Dube in the league stage, and Shardul and Musheer Khan in the knockouts — alongside consistent contributors like Tanush Kotian and Mulani — consistently came to the team's rescue.

Furthermore, the inclusion of Rahane, Salvi, Kulkarni, and Mulani in the core planning group proved pivotal.

A for all-rounders

The secret to Mumbai's remarkable success in the Ranji Trophy knockouts lies in its batting depth and ability to post substantial totals. Throughout the tournament's history, Mumbai's formidable batting



The cricketing adage holds true for the Mumbai team's performance in the 2023-24 season: "Batters win games, and bowlers win championships."